Indeed, such was his beauty that Akbar Khan seems to have become something of a sex symbol in 1830s Kabul. Maulana Hamid Kashmiri, the author of the *Akbarnama*, the first epic poem written in his honour, gives over several pages to his wedding-night athletics with his lovely bride, the daughter of Mohammad Shah Ghilzai, 'this houri of paradise, as bright as the sun, who put the moon and stars to shame'.

> Desire moved on both sides
> Passion was inflamed as they sought each other
>
> They laid bare their faces from the curtain of modesty
> The veil of clothing they threw off
>
> They clasped one another so close
> As perfume to the rose and colour to the tulip
>
> They lay with each other in pleasure and delight
> Body to body, face to face, lip to lip
>
> Sometimes the fingers would hit upon the moon and the Pleiades
> Sometimes the hand would hasten towards the musk of conquest
>
> His desire swelled from the sweetness of her kiss
> They both redoubled their labours for the prize
>
> Shining, jewel upon jewel, he planted seed
> By a single pearl, the rubies of Badakhshan were scattered[48]

Yet for all his glamour, Akbar was clearly a complex and intelligent man, more emotionally volatile than Dost Mohammad, and also more aesthetically sensitive. He and Masson knew each other well; in fact Akbar Khan had taken Masson under his protection and showed more interest than any other Afghan in the Hellenised Gandharan Buddhist sculptures that Masson had been excavating from the Kushan monasteries around Jalalabad. 'He was enraptured with two female heads,' wrote Masson in his memoirs,

> and lamented that the ideal beauties of the sculpture could not be realized in nature. From this time on a kind of acquaintance subsisted between us, and the young sirdar would frequently send for me. I became a pretty constant visitor at his tea-table, and procured from him an order, addressed to several of the maleks [tribal leaders] and chiefs, to assist me in any researches I